

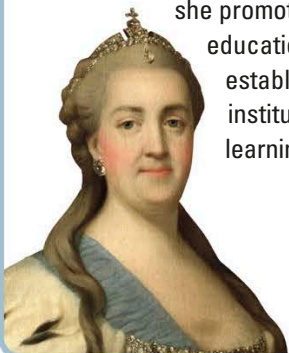


▲ WAR AGAINST NAPOLEON

French emperor Napoleon I invaded Russia in 1812, but suffered heavy losses due to harsh winter conditions and food shortages. After defeating French forces at the Battle of Leipzig, Russia and its allies marched into Paris, the French capital, in March 1814, forcing Napoleon to go into exile.

CATHERINE THE GREAT

Catherine the Great (reigned 1762–1796) was a German princess who overthrew her husband, Peter III of Russia, to rule the empire in her own right. Intelligent and cultured, she promoted women's education, and established institutions for learning in Europe.



Imperial Russia

Russia became an empire in 1721 (see pp.124–125), and over the next 200 years expanded its territory and slowly emerged as a major European power. Despite this, the people of Russia were largely illiterate and poor, and by 1917 they had risen up in revolt against their rulers.

Imperial Russia was ruled by a single family, the Romanov Dynasty. Though the empire slowly industrialized, the czars failed to modernize their government and introduce reforms. The country was largely rural, and right up until the mid-19th century many ordinary people working the land were serfs—unfree people with few rights (see p.124).

Jews were forced to live in a poor region known as the Pale of Settlement. In the late 19th century, violent massacres forced many Jews to migrate to the West.

The pace of industrialization picked up in the mid-19th century, which created more jobs for people. Aware of the wide gap between rich and poor, workers began to demand more rights, leading eventually to the downfall of the Romanovs. Yet this social unrest overlapped with great artistic developments in Russia. Writers such as Leo Tolstoy and Alexander Pushkin wrote fine novels and poems, while composers like Pyotr Tchaikovsky and Igor Stravinsky created musical works that drew worldwide fame.